

Harbor & Pine Studio employee handbook

Harbor & Pine Studio is a fictional photography studio. This handbook is sample text for a portfolio demo. It is not a real policy, and it does not describe a real employer.

Welcome

Harbor & Pine Studio makes still photographs for small shops, architects, and the occasional cookbook. The studio is a rented room with a north window, a rolling table, and a cupboard of clamps. We are a small team on purpose. You will know everyone by the end of your first week.

Read this handbook once when you join, and again when your life changes: a move, a child, a long trip, a new laptop. The version in the shared folder is the one that counts. If a sentence here disagrees with a newer note from the studio lead, follow the newer note and tell us so we can fix the page.

We hire people who are careful with other people's things. Clients lend us rooms, objects, and trust. Return both in better shape than you found them.

How the week works

Core hours are 10:00 to 15:00 in Pacific Time, Monday to Thursday. Those hours are for overlap: feedback, client calls, and the kind of question that is painful in writing. Outside that window, set your own start and stop as long as the week's work is done and your calendar shows when you are free.

Friday is a quiet day. No internal meetings after 11:00. Use it to finish, to file, or to take the day if your PTO balance allows. The studio phone forwards to the lead. You do not have to sit near it.

We do not track keystrokes or idle time. We do look at whether the work left the building in the shape we promised. If a week goes quiet, your manager will ask what is in the way, not how many hours the laptop was open.

Meetings start on the minute and end five minutes early. Decline a meeting that has no purpose written on the invite. A written note is often enough.

Remote work

Most of the team works from home. The studio room is there for shoots and for anyone who wants a change of wall. Book the room on the shared calendar before you travel in. If two people need it, the shoot wins, then the person who booked first.

Home setups should include a chair you can sit in for a day, a lamp that is not a ceiling glare, and a

door or a corner that can be quiet during a client call. The studio will reimburse a one-time setup within the equipment section of this handbook. We do not pay rent, and we do not pay for a second monitor beyond the standard kit unless your role edits stills all day.

You are expected to be reachable on chat during core hours. Status should say if you are in a shoot, at lunch, or away. Silence for a whole core block, with no note, is the thing we will ask about. A note that says "back at 14:00" is enough.

Internet at home is your responsibility up to a normal residential connection. If a shoot day requires a guaranteed upload, come into the studio or tell the producer the day before so we can plan a courier for the cards.

Pets and children can appear on camera. We like them. Move the call if the background becomes the meeting. Clients should not hear a conversation they were not invited to.

Working abroad

Staff may work away from their home region for up to 30 consecutive days in a calendar year. That is the longest single stretch. Two shorter trips still count against the same 30 day pool. Thirty consecutive days is the limit we mean when someone asks about a month away.

Ask your manager at least two weeks before you go. Tell us the dates, the time zone you will keep, and whether core hours in Pacific Time still work. If the gap is more than three hours, we will look at the shoot calendar before we say yes. Approval is written, even if it is only a short chat message you both can find later.

Pay stays on the home payroll. The studio does not sponsor work permission, visas, or tax registrations for time away. You are responsible for the right to do the work from where you sit, and for any tax that follows you. If you are unsure, ask an advisor before you book the ticket. We are not that advisor.

You must be able to join core hours, or a written substitute overlap that your manager accepts. A shoot that needs you in the room still needs you in the room. Equipment you take with you stays on the studio inventory and should travel in the padded case. Loss outside the home region is still loss: file the note the day you notice.

The studio can say no when a client week is heavy, when the team is already thin, or when the dates collide with a close. We would rather say no early than pull you back mid-trip.

Paid time off

Full-time staff accrue paid time off from the first day. The balance is 20 days per year, plus the studio holidays listed in the shared calendar. Accrual is visible in the payroll tool on the first of each

month. Days do not expire at year end; you may carry 5 days into January, and anything above that is paid out on the January payroll.

Request days in the shared calendar as soon as you know them. One or two days need a note to your manager. A week or more needs two weeks of notice so shoots can move. We try to say yes. We will say no if you are the only person who can run a booked set that week, and we will help you pick a different week.

Sick time is separate and is not counted against the 20 days. Stay home when you are ill. Write "sick" on the calendar; you do not owe a diagnosis. If you are out more than three days in a row, the lead will check in about coverage, not about proof.

Holidays that fall on a Saturday are taken on Friday. Holidays that fall on a Sunday are taken on Monday. If you would rather work the holiday and take a different day, swap it on the calendar and tell your manager.

Unpaid leave is possible after PTO is exhausted, for up to 10 more days in a year, with the lead's written yes. Benefits continue through that stretch. Longer unpaid leave is a conversation, not a form.

Parental leave

A parent who has worked here for at least 90 days may take 12 weeks of leave at full pay for the birth, adoption, or foster placement of a child. The 12 weeks can start up to two weeks before the date you expect the child, and they can be split into two blocks within the first six months if you say so in writing before the first block starts.

Tell the studio lead as soon as you are ready. We will ask for the rough dates, not for medical detail. A colleague will cover your recurring client, and you will write a one page handoff: where the files live, what is promised, and who likes to be called versus emailed.

During leave you are not expected to check chat. If you want a short monthly note about the studio, say so. We will not send the noise by default. Your accounts stay active so you can read that note if you asked for it.

If two parents both work here, each has their own 12 weeks. You may take them at the same time or in sequence. A shoot calendar does not override this section. We will hire a freelancer before we ask you to cut the leave short.

Return can be gradual: three days a week for the first two weeks back, at full pay, if you request it before you return. Core hours still apply on the days you work.

Expenses

Spend studio money as if you were explaining it to a client who is kind and precise. If a cost is under \$75 and it is clearly for a shoot or for the office, buy it and file the receipt within 14 days. Above \$75, ask first, unless the shoot is underway and the alternative is a failed day. A same-day note after an emergency purchase is still required.

Receipts go in the expenses folder with the date and the job name in the file name. Cards, cash, and personal cards are all fine. Personal cards are reimbursed on the next payroll after the receipt is in. We do not reimburse alcohol except one modest toast at a client dinner the producer already approved.

Travel to a shoot outside your usual city is booked through the producer: train or a reasonable flight, a room under the cap written in the job brief, and meals up to the daily figure in that same brief. If the brief is silent, ask before you book the room. Rides to the set are reimbursed. Rides to dinner are not, unless the producer grouped the team on purpose.

Software subscriptions in your own name are not reimbursed. Ask for a studio seat. A font, a one-week rental of a lens, or a prop under the \$75 line can go on a receipt.

If you are refused a reimbursement, you will get a sentence that says why. Appeal once to the studio lead. The second answer stands.

Equipment

The standard kit is a laptop, a charger, a headset, and a 27 inch display if you edit. Photographers also get a body, two lenses from the cupboard list, and a card reader. The kit is logged when it leaves the shelf. You sign the row. When you leave the studio, the kit comes back in the same week, clean and with the chargers.

You may request one extra item in your first month, up to \$250, for the home setup: a chair, a lamp, a stand, or a better headset. Send the link. We order it to the studio or approve a receipt. It is studio property. Mark it on the same inventory row.

Personal machines are allowed for chat and mail. Client files and raw cards stay on the studio laptop and on the studio drive. Do not keep a second copy on a personal computer "just in case." The case is the backed-up drive, not a drawer of old laptops.

Repairs go through the lead. Do not open a laptop. If something is stolen, file a local report, tell us the same day, and we will start the insurance note. A lost charger is not an emergency, but do tell us so the next person is not short.

Upgrades happen when the machine is slow for the work, not on a fixed birthday. Ask with an

example: an export that now takes an hour, a battery that dies before lunch. We would rather replace early than watch a shoot day fail.

Security

Use the studio password manager. Unique passwords. The manager is not optional for client galleries, the bank, or the shared drive. Turn on the screen lock at five minutes on every studio laptop. Full-disk encryption stays on. If a vendor asks you to turn it off to "make a driver work," stop and ask the lead.

Client files live in the job folder. The job folder is the only place. Mail attachments of full-resolution work are a last resort, and only as a link that expires in seven days. Do not post behind-the-scenes frames that show a client's unreleased product, even to a private account.

Phishing shows up here as fake invoices and fake gallery logins. If a message is urgent about money or a password, it is probably not us. We will never ask for your password in chat. Call the person if the request is odd. A sixty-second call is cheaper than a drained account.

Report a lost laptop, a shared password, or a strange login the hour you notice. You will not be punished for a fast report. You will have a harder conversation if we learn about it from a client. Lock the account first if you still can, then write down what you clicked.

Visitors in the studio do not get the Wi-Fi password for the office network. They get the guest network, which does not see the drive. Whiteboards with client names get wiped at the end of the day.

Code of conduct

Treat colleagues, clients, and anyone who delivers lunch as if they will describe the conversation later. No slurs. No jokes at the expense of a person in the room or out of it. Critique the photograph, the schedule, and the invoice. Do not critique a person's body, accent, or family.

Harassment, including repeated requests after a clear no, is a reason to be asked to leave. If you see it, you can tell the studio lead or the person we name as the alternate contact on the contact page. You can also write it down and send it later the same week. We will listen before we decide. Retaliation for a good-faith report is itself a breach.

Credit is part of the conduct. If a colleague styled the set or found the location, their name goes in the job notes. Clients sometimes ask for a single name on a caption. The internal note still lists the crew.

Gifts from clients over \$40 go in the shared kitchen or back to the sender with a kind note. A book about the project can stay. Cash never stays.

Conflicts of interest should be said out loud. If your roommate bids on a build we might photograph, you do not get to choose the bid. Step out of the thread and tell the lead why.

How to ask for help

Start with your manager for schedule, feedback, and priorities. Start with the producer for dates, travel, and client tone. Start with the studio lead for pay, leave, equipment, and anything that feels like a rule is wrong.

Write the question with the date you need an answer. "Before Thursday" is more useful than "soon." Attach the file or the link. A question with the context in the first three lines gets a faster yes.

If you are stuck on a creative call, show two options and say which one you lean toward. We will edit a choice faster than we will invent one from a blank page.

This handbook will not cover every case. When it is silent, choose the option that is kind, reversible, and easy to explain. Then tell us, so the next edition can include it.

Shoots

A shoot day has a producer, a lead photographer, and whoever else the brief names. The call time on the calendar is when work starts, not when you roll in to look for coffee. Arrive early enough to find the load-in door. If you will be late, write the producer before you are late, with a new time they can plan around.

The job folder is opened the day the job is confirmed. It contains the brief, the shot list, the contact, and a notes file. Read the brief before you ask a question the brief already answers. If the brief is wrong, fix it in the file and tell the producer in the same hour, so the old version does not keep circulating as a screenshot.

On set, the photographer calls the frame. Assistants do not redirect a client in front of the client. If something is unsafe, anyone can stop the room. A stop is not a debate. Move the light, the ladder, or the person, then talk about why.

Cards are labeled with the job short name and the date before they go in a body. Full cards come out of the body before anyone leaves the building, and they are copied to the studio drive before they are formatted. Two copies, then format. One copy is not a backup. The producer confirms the copy before the team breaks down.

Client reviews happen on the gallery link, not in a long email of attachments. The first edit is the photographer's selects, usually within three working days of the shoot. The client has five working days to comment. Silence after a reminder is treated as acceptance of the selects, and we say that in the delivery note so it is not a surprise.

Weather, a locked building, or a client who does not show: the producer decides whether the day is a reschedule or a reduced list. You will not be asked to invent a full set from an empty room and pretend it was the brief. Write what happened in the notes file the same day, in plain sentences.

Files and names

Name files so a stranger can sort them. Job short name, date as year-month-day, then a short word for what it is. "northroom-2026-04-02-selects" is enough. "final-FINAL-v7" is not. Dates in the name beat dates in a memory.

Raw files stay in the raw folder. Exports stay in the export folder. Do not mix them. Do not rename a raw file after ingest; the camera name is the identity we can match back to a card. Selects are copies or a list, not a pile of renamed originals.

The shared drive is the record. A laptop is a working copy. If your laptop dies, the drive should still have last night's ingest. That only works if you copied before you slept. The end of a shoot day includes the copy. It is part of the day, not an errand for tomorrow.

Delete with care. A client file is kept for 18 months after delivery unless the contract says otherwise. After that, the producer archives or removes it and notes the date. Do not clean a folder because it looks crowded during a busy week. Ask.

Versions of a retouch go in order: the select, then v2, then v3. Do not overwrite v2 if a client might still be looking at it. The delivery note says which version was sent. If you replace a file at the same link, say so.

Feedback and reviews

You will get feedback on the work, and you will give it. Feedback names the frame, the sentence, or the schedule, and it says what to do next. "I do not like it" is not feedback. "The highlight on the bottle clips, try a larger source" is feedback.

Reviews happen twice a year, in a 45 minute conversation with your manager. The notes are a shared page you can both edit before the meeting. Bring two jobs you are proud of and one you would do differently. Pay is discussed in the same season, in a separate note from the studio lead, so the creative conversation does not turn into a negotiation by accident.

If you want a new responsibility, write it down: what it is, what you would stop doing to make room, and how we would know it is going well after two months. We take that more seriously than a hint in a meeting.

A hard week is not a review. If a job went badly, debrief it while the notes are fresh, then let it sit. We do not stack a formal review on top of a bad Tuesday.

People grow at different speeds here. A photographer who wants to produce, or a producer who wants to shoot, can try a small job with a partner. The partner is there to catch the miss, not to grade you. Tell us if the try should become the job.

When you leave Harbor & Pine, we will write a simple confirmation of your dates and your role. Portfolio use of client work follows the client agreement, which is often "ask first." We will help you ask. We will not promise a client will say yes.